prepared the ground for India to become a traditional military and economic Great Power but emphasized the possibility of using its capabilities to forge cooperation. Golwalkar was less coy about India's Great Power pathway and more cynical about international cooperation.

China in Indian worldviews

What do these worldviews mean for Indian attitudes towards China? Strictly speaking, the *Arthashastra*'s advice is directed at a ruler (or a country) aiming to be a vijigisu. It is hard to imagine India aiming to be a vijigisu in relation to China. China's size, the stopping power of the Himalaya, the massive Tibetan plateau, and the plains of China beyond Tibet make any thought of conquest in a literal sense impossible. Yet as a powerful neighbour, it must be regarded as a rival. Its neighbours are potential allies of India. However, many neighbours of China are also neighbours of India. Bhutan, Nepal, and Pakistan are therefore simultaneously potential rivals of India *and* China. Given their location between the two powers and given their size, they are probably better thought of as neutrals and mediators. In fact, though, they appear increasingly like allies of China against India. This has certainly been the case with Pakistan since 1963. Nepal and Bhutan could conceivably change their stance too.

From the Kautilyan point of view, then, it is only China's distant neighbours that are possible allies of India – primarily Russia and Japan. Unfortunately for India, while a Kautilyan view may suggest that Russia should see China as its greatest worry, the Russians regard the US and European powers as their biggest concern. Moscow has therefore made common cause with Beijing even as it remains friendly to Delhi. As a result, Russia appears as a mediator between India and China rather than as India's ally against China. In September 2020, at the trilateral summit of Russia, India, and China, Moscow played just such a mediatory role. What about Japan? It does fear China, but it has limitations as an ally, in part because of